March 16-27, 2026

Innovation Challenge March 2026

Welcome to the March hackathon!

If you missed our kick off conversation, check out the recording to get advice on how to get the most from this hackathon!

Watch the orientation video to see how to register for the hackathon and how to use the Innovation Studio site to set up a project and connect with a team

Official Rules

By participating in this Hackathon you are agreeing to the **INNOVATION CHALLENGE HACKATHON OFFICIAL RULES.**

How to get started

1. Choose a Challenge
2. Create a project or Explore projects to find a team
3. Set up the GitHub repository for your project
4. Check out the Activities tab to find helpful sessions
5. Questions? Check out the Discussions or send mail to msdev@microsoft.com

About Projects

Hackers will be participating in teams of 2-5. Teams come together around a Project where you show the community what you are working on. One member of the team should start the Project by clicking on the “+ Create project” button in the upper right of this page. The Project Owner can then invite team members to join or members can find and join the Project themselves from the Projects page. By the end of the Hackathon your Project should include

- A short description

- The Challenge you are solving

- A video featuring a demo of your project, including a presentation describing your project goals, your solution components and architecture, how you thought through your approach, and any key learnings

- The PowerPoint presentation from your video

- A link to your code repository on GitHub

Choose the Challenge you will solve

On the “Challenges” tab, review the use cases and with your team, choose the one for which you will build a solution. Add that information to your team’s project page.

Set up the GitHub repository where you will collaborate

A repository contains all of your code, your files, and each file's revision history. You can discuss and manage your work within the repository. Learn more about working with repos.

Advisors

Software development happens in a community of people willing to help each other build new capabilities. Coaches from our sponsored organizations and Microsoft employees are making themselves available to answer questions and coach teams through their journey. You can search for advisors on the “Find Advisors” tab.

Events and resources

Be sure to tune in to the kick off where we’ll give tips about how to have a successful hackathon. And throughout duration of the hackathon we’ll feature helpful sessions where you can get advice, guidance and learn from the community. You can find both the live and recorded videos on our YouTube playlist

We’ll also be posting links to other resources and materials using a GitHub repo we created for this event, including Discussions. We invite you to jump in to share and help each other too!

Prizes

Entries will be judged by Microsoft subject matter experts.

The best entries will be awarded prizes to be divided equally among all members.

- One $10,000 top prize
- Two $5,000 second place prizes
- Three $2,500 third place prizes

Judging will happen the week of March 30, based on the following criteria and weighting

- Performance 25%
- Innovation 25%
- Breadth of Azure services used 25%
- Responsible AI 25%

Grounded Knowledge Assistant for Regulated Teams

A governed RAG system for compliance-critical questions

Description

Regulated teams (legal, compliance, finance, healthcare) need fast answers from enterprise documents without risking hallucinations or policy violations. Build a governed Retrieval-Augmented Generation (RAG) system that answers complex questions using internal policies, contracts, and SOPs while remaining fully traceable, source-grounded, and measurable. Every response must cite source fragments, apply safety checks, and demonstrate reduced hallucination risk through evaluation metrics. Teams should consider explainability, compliance patterns, and how the solution could evolve from proof-of-concept into a production-ready system with observability and auditability.

Resources

Responsible AI Toolbox
Synthetic Legal Contract Dataset
Material Contracts Corpus
Contract Understanding Atticus Dataset (CUAD)
ContractNLI
WHO Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs)
Responsible AI Toolbox

Lab Notebook AI Assistant

An AI lab partner for experimental reasoning and analysis

Description

Researchers want help reasoning over experiments without replacing scientific judgment. Build an agentic lab notebook assistant that interprets experimental protocols, suggests next-step variations, and analyzes results from text, CSVs, or images—while clearly explaining why recommendations are made. The system must enforce strong safety boundaries (especially in biological or clinical domains), apply content filtering, and avoid disallowed advisory behavior. Teams should focus on explainability, safe agent design, and robust data and model orchestration.

Resources

OpenML
Kaggle Sensor Datasets
Azure ML Examples
Python OpenAI Samples
Content Safety Studio
Responsible AI Toolbox